

we might style the “fabricated” transmission of the text—the scribes made deliberate changes in the text (for whatever reasons), producing fabricated copies, not true copies. I am well aware that the MSS plotted on the figure below contain both careless and deliberate errors, in different proportions (7Q5, 4, 8 and P^{52,64,67} are too fragmentary to permit the classification of their errors as deliberate rather than careless), so that any classification such as I attempt here must be relative and gives a distorted picture. Still, I venture to insist that ignorance, carelessness, officiousness and malice all left their mark upon the transmission of the New Testament text, and we must take account of them in any attempt to reconstruct the history of that transmission.

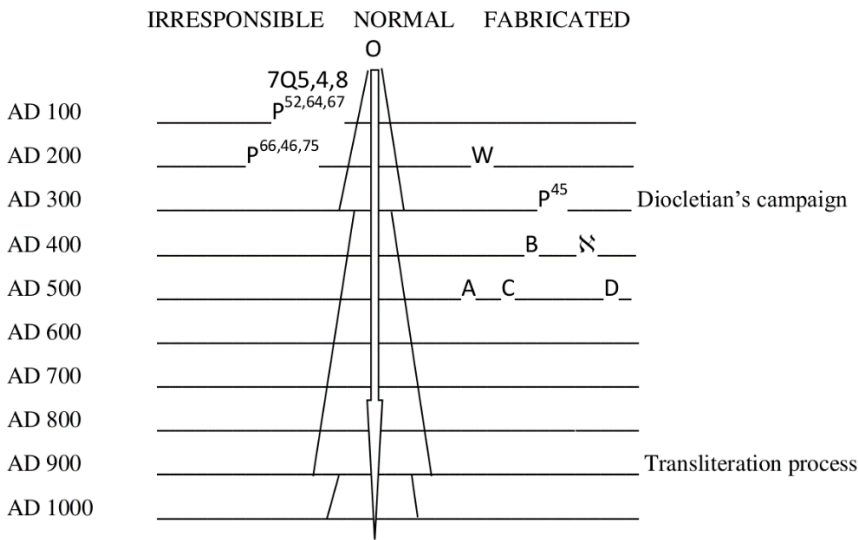


Figure A¹

As the figure suggests, I argue that Diocletian’s campaign had a purifying effect upon the stream of transmission. In order to withstand torture rather than give up your MS(S), you would have to be a truly committed believer, the sort of person who would want good copies of the Scriptures. Thus it was probably the more contaminated MSS that were destroyed, in the main, leaving the purer MSS to replenish the earth.² The arrow within the cones represents Family 35 (see Part II below).

¹ The history of the place where Codex W was found suggests that it must have been copied before AD 200: it was found in the ruins of a town that was abandoned in 200 AD when its water dried up. That town is in an isolated area surrounded by desert. Since W shows Byzantine influence, that text-type already existed in the second century.

² For a fuller discussion of this point please see the section “Imperial repression of the